



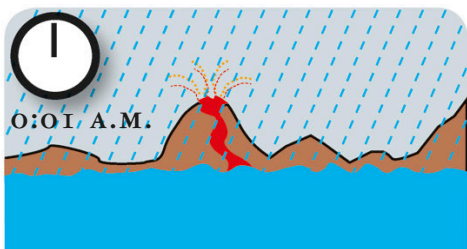
Evolution of life



Let's turn 4.6 billion years
of evolution into one day...

Life on Earth began around 3.5 billion years ago. For many long years, life consisted of little more than single-celled organisms surviving in challenging conditions. Gradually, things began to change—animals and plants moved out of the water and onto the land. It's difficult to imagine just how long it took to arrive at the plants and animals we see today, but if you think of it in terms of a day humans didn't emerge until nearly midnight!

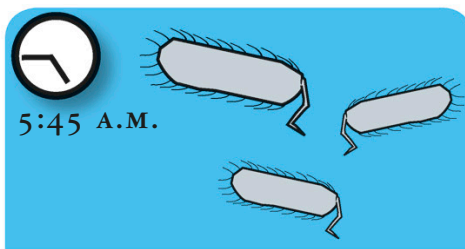
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GETTING STARTED

Earth forms. It is little more than a hot rock with a poisonous atmosphere. As it cools, the molten surface hardens to form a solid crust. At some point it starts raining and the oceans form.

4,600 million years ago



FIRST LIFE

Conditions are still hostile, but simple prokaryote cells have begun to emerge in the ocean. Some of these are blue-green algae (cyanobacteria) that gradually oxygenate the water and the atmosphere.

3,500 million years ago

*For the first
three billion
years, not a
lot happened!*